INTRODUCTION:

Navigating city agency processes and local permitting requirements can be intimidating. The approvals needed to host an event are often contingent on your ability to provide the correct information to the correct people at the correct time.

Whether it is a first-year race or a race that has been around for decades, there is an expectation that events contribute value to the community while minimizing the negative impacts on its constituents. The priorities of the community and its definition of “value” can change over time. Events must be able to recognize this evolution and adapt their operations plans to remain a positive influence.

As the Race Director, you are your event’s strongest advocate. In this section, we will review the importance of building relationships that solidify your event’s place in the local fabric of the community and provide strategies for approaching:

- City Agencies
- Permitting
- Economic Impact
- Environmental Impact
- Community Relations

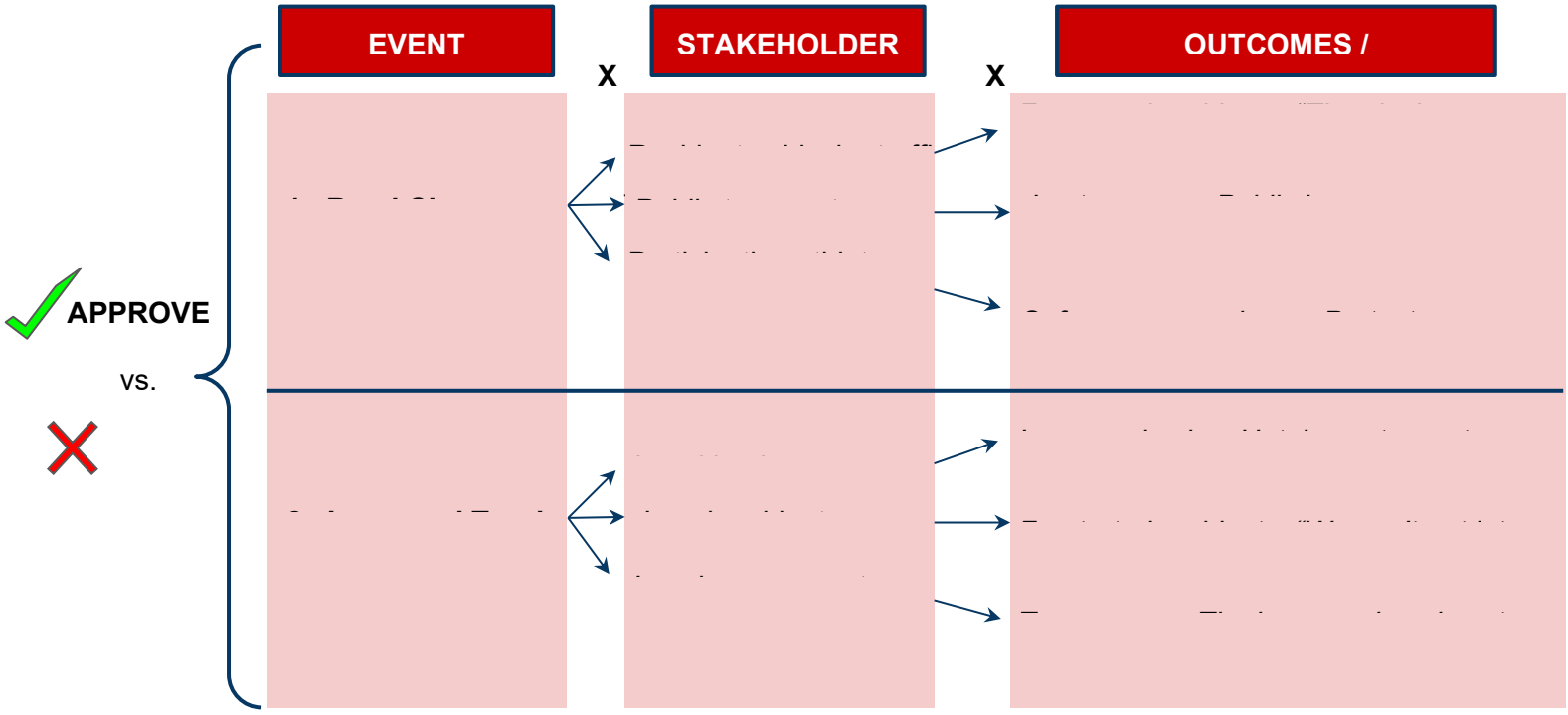
**Note: While this guide does provide recommendations for city agency coordination and permitting, all planning and decision-making regarding the event is at the discretion of the Race Director. While direction is provided on the competition rules, it is not a replacement for the competition rules. For questions about the rules and their application at your event, please reach out to rulesandofficials@usatriathlon.org.*

CITY AGENCIES:

Without approval from municipal agencies, even the best event ideas are just that - ideas. Transforming a race concept into reality starts with garnering support from local municipalities. The ability to establish strong relationships with these key contacts can make or break your event.

Risk Assessment: At its core, the decision for agencies to approve/deny events is an exercise in Risk Assessment. They evaluate if the rewards of hosting the event will outweigh the risks. While the premise is simple, the process is not always black and white. The number of variables to weigh increases exponentially as you start to consider the different event impacts, the affected stakeholders, and the potential outcomes. The public's perception of a situation is also an important factor in the equation and we know perception does not always match reality. People draw conclusions based on the information they have at the time and sometimes, these perceptions can take on lives of their own.

Here are a couple of examples to help illustrate the complex web of considerations. As the event size, duration, and footprint increases, this list only continues to grow:



As you work with city agencies, it is important not to have tunnel vision. As the event producer, the race is obviously your top priority (as it should be!), but it is important to understand the agencies you work with have many other stakeholders to answer to, each with their own set of priorities. It is their job to advocate for solutions that promote the safety and well-being of the community at large. Oftentimes, they walk a tightrope, attempting to please all parties involved. By proactively coming to the table with ways to minimize potential negative impacts on other groups, you show you have a realistic understanding of the challenges they face and genuine concern for how your event affects others. It's all about compromise!

Relationship Building: The decision to approve events happens days, weeks, months, or sometimes years before the race will occur. This means agencies are making approval decisions based on plans, projections, and anticipated outcomes. Race Directors are experienced event professionals able to craft precise operations plans with movements outlined minute-by-minute, but at this stage of the game, these plans are all hypothetical. By approving an event, agencies are staking their organization's reputation on a Race Director's ability to execute the event according to the plans outlined on paper. In essence, they are betting on a horse before they have ever had a chance to see it race. This requires a great deal of trust.

Trust must be earned. A first-year event with a new Race Director may have a shorter leash than a return event with a Race Director who has years of trusted relationships. It may take time for you and your organization to establish a proven track record of success with agencies. Respect the hierarchy and the process. Be patient!

Below are a few ways to strengthen relationships. While most of these are intuitive, it is often the smallest touches that make the biggest difference:

- **Be Prepared:** Pre-event planning meetings are the first opportunity for agencies to see you in action. Presenting your event information in a detailed, organized manner inspires confidence that you will execute the plans with the same care and precision. Comprehensive, well-documented operations and emergency plans show that you have thought through all the moving pieces of the event.

- **Schedule Face-to-Face Meetings**: Emails and virtual meetings may be the most convenient way to communicate, but when possible and appropriate, consider scheduling in-person meetings. Gathering all parties for a site walk-through or face-to-face meeting helps to bring the event elements to life and fosters a greater sense of teamwork.

- **The Three R's:**
    - **Receptive:** Be receptive to feedback and open-minded about potential changes. This may require going back to the drawing board to rework plans. Being willing to compromise shows your commitment to minimizing the impact on other groups.

    - **Responsive:** As a Race Director, your to-do list is always growing, but agency communication should hold a permanent spot at the top of the list. Prioritize providing

MEETING CHECKLIST:

BEFORE THE MEETING:

- Invite all relevant parties
- Create list of objectives
- Circulate the agenda:
    - Introductions
    - Event Overview
    - Proposed plans shared for approval
    - Address questions & concerns
    - Collectively determine next steps
- Prepare and share supporting documents (timelines, site plans, diagrams)

AFTER THE MEETING:

- Share a thank you, with a written recap and outline of next steps
- Establish time for the next meeting

agency partners with any information requested. Don't make them have to chase you for answers!

- **Respectful:** Don't lose sight of the fact that your event is taking place on their turf. They are permitting you to use their facilities and roadways. You are a guest in their home. If you do not respect their rules, you may not be invited back!

- **Do What You Say & Say What You Do:**

DO WHAT YOU SAY

Be true to your word. Do not agree to executing plans unless you are confident you have the resources to do so. While overpromising now may get you the approvals you need in the short term, under-delivering on-site might jeopardize agency relationships in the long term.

&

SAY WHAT YOU DO

Honesty and transparency are key. Share as much detail about your event plans as possible so there are no surprises on race day. The mentality that "we can sneak this through under the radar" or "we'll just hope no one will notice" is never an acceptable strategy.

- **Show Appreciation:** "Please" and "Thank you" go a long way! Agency partners are an integral part of the event and it is important for them to be able to share in the success. Extend invites to agency partners to have access to VIP areas and/or offer to escort them to exclusive areas of the course (i.e. swim start/finish line) to be able to have a memorable race day experience. Post-event, check with your contacts if they can receive donations of remaining t-shirts or swag items that they can distribute to their teams as a thank-you for their time and effort spent on the project.

Pro Tip:
If there are large groups of agency personnel working the event (i.e. police officers, first responders), consider setting up a "City Agency" tent with refreshments where they might be able to grab a cup of coffee and/or a bagged lunch. This is a nice touchpoint that shows the race appreciates the time and effort of all the people with boots on the ground on the day of the event.

PERMITTING:

Permitting processes enable city agencies to strike a balance between allowing community events to occur and safeguarding public welfare, infrastructure, and resources. Permits aim to protect all parties involved in the event by holding race organizers accountable to pre-established health and safety standards that must be followed.

Specific permit requirements and procedures differ based on the event's location, components, and size so it is essential to check with local, city, county, state, and/or federal agencies that have jurisdiction in your area. While the process varies, the objective is generally the same: collect event details in an organized manner that can be formally reviewed and circulated to relevant parties. The process helps to kickstart larger conversations with city agency partners to review the event logistics and prepare for day-of execution.

Here are a few typical steps in the permitting process:

1	RACE DIRECTOR	**Define the Event**: Determine the event date, schedule, venue location(s), course route, expected attendance, and event components
2	RACE DIRECTOR	**Research & Outreach:** Gather information on the permitting process in your area. Many municipalities have permitting guidance for special events on their websites. Research available resources, consult other local race producers, and reach out to agency contacts at relevant permitting offices to review the permitting requirements.
3	RACE DIRECTOR	**Complete the Permit Application**: Obtain the official permit application and fill it out with detailed information about the event, including: • **Supporting Documents**: Examples include site plans, production schedules, route maps, traffic control plans, security plans, etc. • **Certificate(s) of Insurance**: Based on specifications provided by the agency • **Application Fee**: Permits typically have an application fee, which can vary based on the size and scope of the event. • **Bond**: Some events may require a bond or security deposit which will be returned post-event if all conditions of the permit are followed
4	AGENCY	**Review & Approval:** The permitting authority will review the application which may involve coordination with various city departments. • **Community Input:** Some municipalities require public hearings where

		event organizers need to present the event details to the community in an open forum. Community members have an opportunity to raise concerns and provide input in the approval process. • **Conditions & Modifications:** If necessary, city agencies may impose conditions or modifications to the event plans. Event organizers may need to address any concerns raised during the review process.
5	AGENCY	**Permit Issuance:** Once the application is approved and all conditions are met the event permit will be issued. This document outlines the terms and conditions for hosting the event.
6	RACE DIRECTOR + AGENCY	**Resource Coordination:** Leading up to the event, Race Directors should work closely with agency contacts to review logistics and safety plans. Confirm if there are city resources that will have involvement in the event (i.e. EMS, sanitation, traffic safety, etc.) and supplement with private providers where applicable.
7	RACE DIRECTOR	**Event Execution:** Execute the event in accordance with the approved permit. Adhere to all conditions and guidelines specified in the permit and ensure compliance with local regulations.
8	RACE DIRECTOR + AGENCY	**Post-Event Debrief:** After the event, the Race Director and relevant city agencies should conduct a debrief to review the successful race elements and those that may require additional attention or modification in future years.

The types of permits needed for your race will vary depending on the requirements of the area where the event is held. To help guide initial conversations with local agencies, below is a list of common permit types. Review the list with your municipal contacts to see if any of these are required or if there are any other requirements specific to your jurisdiction:

TYPES OF PERMITS:	
TYPE	**DESCRIPTION**
VENUE	
Special Event Permit	May be required to host a group activity at your event venue(s). This permit generally grants permission for the space rental and use.
On-Site Sales	Authorization may be required for revenue-generating activities on-site. Note that the venue may require a revenue-share where they are entitled to a percentage of the funds.
Temporary Place of Assembly	May be required for outdoor venues where occupants will be gathering in an enclosed space. It establishes the maximum occupancies and egress routes for the area.
Public Solicitation License	May be required for non-profit organizations to solicit funds from the general public on-site at the event.

COURSE	
US Coast Guard Marine Event Permit	May be required if your event is being held on or near navigable waters. Consult with the authority that governs the body of water used for the swim course.
Street Event Permit	May be required for events that involve public streets, curb lanes or sidewalks. Inquire about local street use permits as well as any state requirements through the Department of Transportation
Traffic Control Plans / Maintenance of Traffic (MOTs)	Work in conjunction with local law enforcement to determine the traffic safety plans. Some jurisdictions will require the submission of formal MOTs created by a registered professional engineer
Installation/Removal/Modification of existing street infrastructure	If your course requires any modification to existing infrastructure such as bollards, street signs, or traffic signals, a permit may be required.
EQUIPMENT	
Temporary Structure Permit	May be required for the erection of temporary structures, platforms, stages, and/or trussing. Typically, there are size thresholds that outline the need for a permit (i.e. square footage of a tent or trussing height)
Amplified Sound Permit	May be required to have amplified sound on-site at the event. Take note of any sound ordinances that exist in the community that may prohibit sound during certain timeframes.
Hydrant Permit	May be required to use hydrants as a water source for the event. Specific requirements may exist around the hydrant flushing process, sanitation measures, and the use of backflow prevention devices.
Generator Permit	May be required for the use of portable generators. Specific requirements may exist for spill containment, the distance they can be placed from structures (i.e. tents, portajohns), and/or the presence of a fire extinguisher.
After Hours Variances	May be necessary for any install/breakdown / use of equipment that happens outside of standard business hours or on the weekends.
FOOD & BEVERAGE	
Temporary Food Service	May be required for the temporary sale or service of food on-site
Cooking / Open Flame Permit	May be required for the use of open flames on-site, for cooking and/or decorative purposes
Temporary Beer, Wine, and Cider Permit	May be required to authorize the service/sale of beer, wine, and/or cider on-site
Caterer’s License	May be required to actively pour and serve alcoholic beverages on-site

PUBLIC HEALTH	
Health Department Permits	Check the Department of Health requirements for your state as large-scale events may be required to submit a permit for mass public gatherings to ensure the safe and adequate provision of EMS on-site at the event
Department of Sanitation	Consult with the Department of Sanitation for any trash collection/recycling regulations for the collection and removal of event waste

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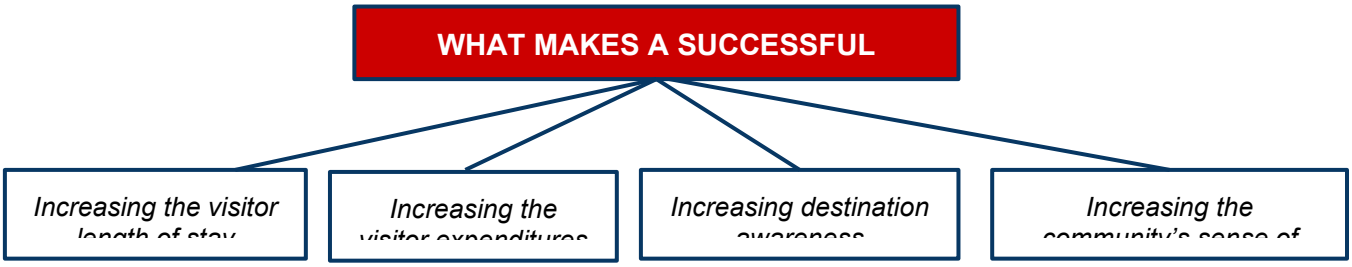
ECONOMIC IMPACT:

One of the biggest selling points of events is that they bring an influx of spending that helps boost revenues for the local economy. Races are attractions that have drawing power and staying power. This means that they not only bring in new visitors, but they help to keep visitors in the area longer.

Tourism Boards: Many communities have local Tourism Boards that help to support and market activities that make the area an attractive tourist destination. These groups can be a great resource during the planning and development phase by leveraging their relationships to help garner the support of permitting agencies. They can help ingratiate the event with the local community. In some instances, they may be able to provide grants or donations to financially contribute to the event.

Goals and Objectives: Consult with city agencies and the tourism board to learn more about the goals they have set for their community. What does a successful event look like in their eyes? Work together to create event operations plans that help to support the achievement of these goals. Positioning your event as a vehicle that can help bring about positive progress, provides the community and its leadership with an incentive to support the race.



Measuring Economic Impact: Economic impact studies provide a quantitative way to measure an event's financial contribution to the local community. Being able to see the dollar amounts in black and white makes the impact more tangible, allowing all parties involved to make data-driven decisions about the event. Consider hiring a consulting firm that specializes in economic analysis to conduct an analysis. Colleges and universities are also a great resource, as students studying economics and statistics are often looking for real-life scenarios where they can apply their research and theory.

The economic impacts of events on the economy of an area are categorized into primary and secondary economic impacts:

- **Primary Impacts:** The actual revenues generated by local businesses as a direct result of the event. This spending includes the following:

RACE MANAGEMENT	ATHLETES & SPECTATORS	SPONSORS & EXHIBITORS
The spending that occurs by race management to prepare the event site for the race. Examples include equipment rentals, supply purchases, and the hiring of local labor support. This is the easiest impact to measure as you can reference receipts and invoices.	Involves estimating the number of visitors (athletes + spectators) and the estimated spending at local establishments such as hotels, restaurants, supermarkets, retail stores, etc. This is typically measured using representative surveys.	The event may draw in tourist sponsors and exhibitors that are activating on-site. These groups will make local purchases of local goods and services to activate their event setups, resulting in an inflow of revenue for local businesses. This is typically measured using representative surveys.

Since economic impact analysis is focused on the effects of the injection of outside revenue, the spending of athletes who live in the community should not be included in the calculations. Representative samples are used to identify approximately how many people are traveling for the event and gather information about their spending habits. This sample data is then applied to the larger population using percentages. Here is an example of an event survey:

City State Zip Code

How many people are in your party

Income Level:

☐ < $40,000 ☐ $40,000 - $75,000 ☐ $75,000- $100,000 ☐ $100,000+

What is your primary reason for being in the area?

☐ I live here ☐ ABC Triathlon

☐ Visiting friends/family ☐ Other _____

If staying away from home, how many nights will you in the area?

Where are you staying?

☐ Private residence ☐ Hotel

☐ Campground ☐ Other _____

How many years have you attended ABC Triathlon?

How did you hear about the event? Check as many as apply

☐ Social Media ☐ Word of Mouth ☐ Radio

☐ Website ☐ Magazine ☐ Attend annually

How much will you spend on the following?
Mark closest amount or write in other amount

Gasoline

☐ $0-$20 ☐ $21-$40 ☐ $41-$60 ☐ Other $____

Food and Drink

Your comments: _____

_____

_____

_____

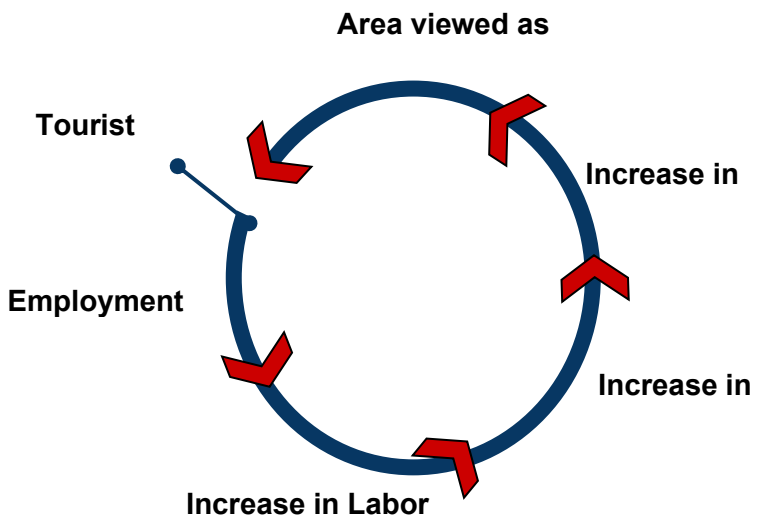
_____

_____

_____

_____

- **Secondary Impacts:** Secondary impacts are the economic boosts that come from the introduction of new money into the economy and the spending of wages and salaries.This is typically calculated using a series of multipliers that show how the spending reverberates through the economy, in the cycle outlined below. This is the piece of the analysis best handled by a trained statistician.



DID YOU KNOW?

With increases in spending, local governments see an influx of revenue from sales tax collected on purchases

Sponsorship / Marketing Opportunities: Events can provide additional value to the community by incorporating city agency logos and content in race marketing and promotion opportunities. This relationship might mirror that of an in-kind sponsorship where the race receives the support of the community to host the event in exchange for a set of entitlements. Examples include: logo on the race website/email blasts, social media content inclusion, and/or on-site PA Announcements. This sort of

agreement recognizes the value of the community's support and helps to promote the area to the race's audience.

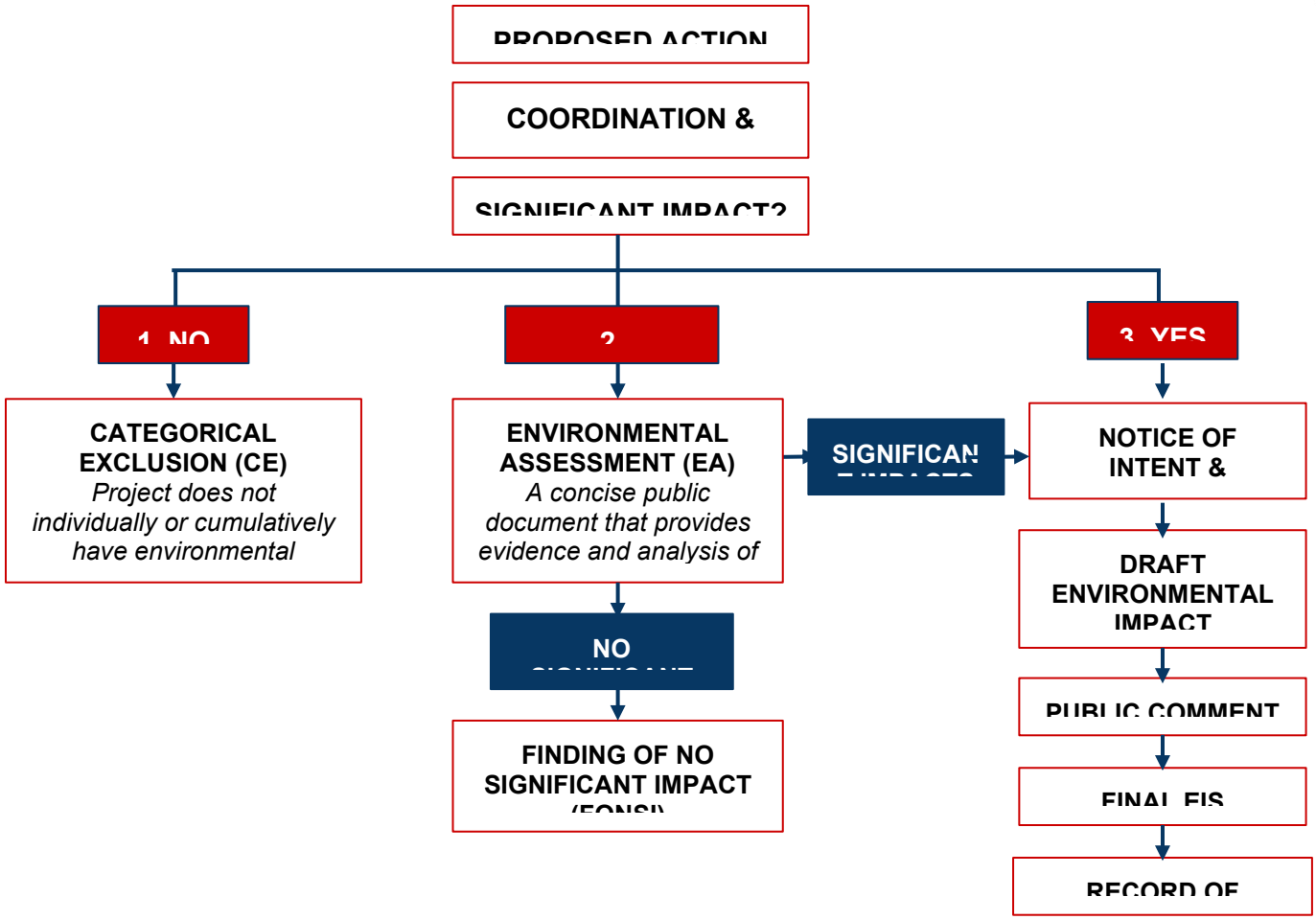
ENVIRONMENTAL IMPACT:

As events undergo the approval process, agencies will consider how the race activities will affect the surrounding environment.

The NEPA Process: The National Environmental Policy Act (NEPA) requires federal agencies that are issuing permits to conduct environmental reviews to consider how proposed actions potentially impact the environment. This tends to come into play for trail, gravel, and cross-triathlon events that might take place on large stretches of public land. Depending on the size, scope, and jurisdiction of your event, the governing agency may be required by the Council on Environmental Quality (CEQ) to undergo and document the NEPA process. The key elements of the process are as follows:

- Determine the event's purpose, need, and range of alternatives to be considered
- Determine potential environmental impacts
- Coordinate with relevant agencies
- Make the information available to the public
- Determine mitigation and unavoidable impacts
- Documentation of the analysis and decisions

Race Directors can support agencies in this process by providing detailed information about the event, including GPS files of course routes, site plans, and operations plans that outline the activities within the utilized areas. Depending on the extent to which the environment is affected, there are three possible ways that the NEPA process plays out:



The NEPA Process involves the consideration of direct, indirect, and cumulative impacts of a proposed action on the environment. Direct effects are caused by the action and occur at the same time and place. Indirect effects are caused by the action but do not occur until later and farther away (off-site), but are still reasonably foreseeable. Cumulative effects consider the results of the action when added to other past, present, or future actions of any and all agencies that are utilizing the area. The process will also take into account any efforts to mitigate any adverse environmental effects.

Mitigation Efforts: Regardless of whether your event will undergo the NEPA Process, it is best practice to explore ways to reduce impact on the areas utilized for the event. Depending on the circumstances, there are a few ways to approach mitigation:

AVOID

Avoid taking the action altogether to prevent the impact

MINIMIZE

Limit the action to reduce the degree to which the area is

RECTIFY

Rectify the impact by repairing, restoring, or

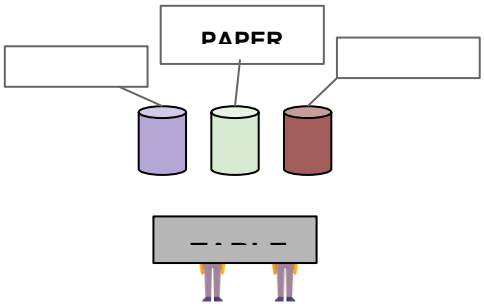
REPLACE

Offset the impact by replacing or enhancing

Below are examples of how races have started to incorporate environmental awareness and advocacy into their events:

- **Waste Diversion Stations:** By sorting on-site waste appropriately races can reduce the amount of waste that is directed to landfills. Consider setting up designated Waste Diversion Stations that are outfitted with signage and personnel to help guide the collection of recyclables, compostables, and landfill-bound trash in separate containers.

Pro Tip:



Set up the Waste Diversion Stations in a way that takes the pressure off the attendee to select the correct collection bin for their item. The sorting of materials will be most effective when it is handled by designated Green Team volunteers/staff who can be briefed before the event on the correct distribution. For example, set up tables in front of the receptacles. Attendees are instructed to set their waste item on the table and the volunteer/staff member then takes the item from the table and drops it in the correct bin.

- **Plogging:** To contribute to the cleanliness of their local communities, some race organizations have started to host plogging events, where participants collect litter along their route. Each participant is provided with trash bags to be able to stop to pick up any litter they encounter during their run/walk. Plogging has become a popular way to bring athletes together and promote awareness for environmental activism. By hosting these events and sharing photos and stories via social media, race organizations can help to spread awareness and inspire others to join the movement.

DID YOU KNOW?

Plogging originated in Sweden. The term “plogging” is a combination of the words “jogging” and “plocka upp”, which is the Swedish word for “pick up”

- **Beautification Projects:** While the focus of sustainability efforts often centers around reducing negative impacts, your organization can also look to introduce positive influences in the environment. Consult with the local governing body about ways you can help enhance the

parks, trails, and forests that comprise your event footprint. Consider engaging your participant community to be part of a Day of Service to plant trees, repaint infrastructure, garden the flower beds, etc. Public Works departments often have a long list of beautification projects that might benefit from additional support and resources.

- **Preventing Fuel Spills:** As you work through the plans for event vehicle movements and equipment orders consider ways you can maximize efficiency and reduce fuel emissions. The presence of generators, light towers, cooking appliances, and/or trucks on-site increases the risk of potential fuel spills. Spilled fuel can seep into the ground contaminating the soil or run into nearby storm drains which can pollute nearby bodies of water. To mitigate these risks, train staff on the proper fuel handling and spill response procedure. Consider incorporating the following equipment measures as part of your contingency planning:

FUEL SAFETY		
SPILL TRAYS	**SPILL KITS**	**FUEL STORAGE**
Position spill trays under heavy equipment (i.e. generators, light towers) as a catch basin for leaks	*Equip production area(s) with universal spill kits to be able to clean any potential spills that may occur*	*Consult local municipalities about any rules and restrictions regarding fuel storage. Consider using storage cabinets or other solutions that can keep fuel secure and contain potential leaks*

COMMUNITY RELATIONS:

When the local community feels a sense of pride in an event, they will be more willing to provide support and resources to help it flourish. But support is a two-way street! The event must take an

active role in engaging with the community throughout the year to show its commitment to all the people that make the race possible.

Race-Related Initiatives: As you start to brainstorm ways to connect, consider the resources you have as a race organizer that offer unique opportunities for community members to engage with the sport. You have the power to create meaningful experiences and give them a way to personally connect with your events. Below are examples of engagement ideas:

BRAINSTORM IDEAS	
Resources	**Initiatives**
Access to Lifeguards	**Swim Clinic**
Race Bibs	**Learn to Ride Class**
Timing Equipment	**Fun Run**
Bike Racks	**Splash & Dash**
Medals	**First Timer Clinic**
Race Entries	**Training Program**

- **Youth Programming:** Fitness programming is a great way to introduce triathlon to the next generation and encourage healthy lifestyles. This can take many forms from organized fun runs, to swim clinics, to classes that teach kids how to ride a bike.

USA Triathlon encourages Race Directors to host a **Splash & Dash** aquathlon (swim-run) event for kids ages 7-15. Participants ages 7-10 complete a 100-meter swim and an approximate 1-kilometer run and participants ages 11-15 complete a 200-meter swim, followed by a 2-kilometer run. USA Triathlon provides a finisher medal for all participants. In addition, USA Triathlon will donate 10 free youth memberships directly to race directors and clubs for every youth-sanctioned race and youth club. Race directors and clubs are encouraged to distribute these memberships to underserved and underrepresented youth and communities at their discretion.

Pro Tip:
Consider reaching out to the physical education department in the local school districts to collaborate on a program that educates kids on the benefits of healthy living and exercise. Develop a training guide that encourages kids to practice in school and on their own, to work toward participation at an upcoming event or clinic. Engaging the schools provides the kids with a support system from their teachers, peers, and families to set and achieve their goals.

- **Charitable Component:** The synergy between races and charities is a win-win partnership - the race benefits from increased participation and a positive community image, while the charities receive financial support and exposure for their causes. By engaging in joint marketing efforts, races and charities can maximize promotion through co-branded materials, social media campaigns, and press releases highlighting the partnerships:

- **Donation of Entry Fees:** Races pledge to donate a percentage of registration fees to its charity partner(s). Participants sign up for the race with the understanding that a portion of their registration fees will be donated to a specific charity. Some races with multiple partners allow participants to choose their preferred charity from the list of options, allowing them to support the causes that are personally meaningful to them.

- **Fundraising Entries:** Races donate or enable charities to purchase entries. Charities then engage participants to fundraise for the organization in exchange for the entry. Consider working with the charities to help provide additional incentives to participants who fundraise above certain thresholds (i.e. race SWAG, VIP access, etc.)

- **On-Site Sales & Donations**: Beer gardens have become a popular part of post-race finish festivals. In some jurisdictions, permitting agencies may have policies that require a certain percentage of alcohol sales or distribution at events to be donated to non-profit organizations. As you craft your on-site food, beverage, and entertainment offerings, consider if there are ways to incorporate a fundraising component for the race charity partners.

- **Volunteer Group Programs:** Volunteers play a critical role in race day operations, but recruiting enough people to fill the necessary roles can often be a challenge. Consider developing a Volunteer Group Program where registered non-profits, youth sports teams, and/or school groups can qualify to receive monetary donations from the race if they provide a certain number of volunteers to be on-site for designated periods of time. This helps to fill important race roles while creating a way for the community to directly engage with and benefit from the event.

- **F&B and SWAG Donations**: Races will often have leftover pre-race, course, and post-finish food and beverage items. There may also be a surplus of race premiums (i.e. t-shirts, hats, etc) that can be donated to underserved communities. Before the event, reach out to local food banks, churches, and homeless shelters to coordinate a handoff of these materials so they can be utilized by people who need them.

Community-Driven Initiatives: Engage local representatives and city agencies about initiatives they are working to promote within the community and incorporate these elements into your race operations plans. For example, if the local government is focused on sustainability, take steps to reduce waste and encourage recycling on-site at the event. If the community is working to be more inclusive, devote resources to DEIA initiatives within your organization to make your races more accessible. Taking action that shows the event is committed to contributing to positive progress in the community helps to strengthen relationships with city agencies.

DID YOU KNOW?

The media attention generated by events provides a valuable platform to showcase the joint effort of races and their communities to bring about positive change. Supporting events that share their mission can be a powerful way for local governments and agencies to

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